

CW0625021 6/17/05 8:21 AM Page 21

Guardian Weekend spooler 246x292mm trim size

how hard things must be for poor Mrs Cameron, and how terrible they felt for her. Then, with an uncomfortable start, I realised that my mother was giving me a look.

"What exactly do you and Tim do over at Mrs Cameron's all day?" she said.

"Nothing."

"You don't ever play rough or misbehave over at her house, do you?"

"No, ma'am," I said.

"I'd better not find out that you do."

I was troubled all the rest of that evening, and that night, as I lay in bed, I resolved to act better at Mrs Cameron's house. Even if Tim was bad, I would be good. But by the next day — when Tim and I dragged out house-paint and brushes from Mrs Cameron's garage and began to paint a landing strip on the grass — I had forgotten all about it.

"I'm bored," said Tim one hot afternoon in July.

It was the first time either of us had said it aloud. But I was starting to get bored, too. Our firefights had slowed. Now, when we died, we took longer and longer getting up to fight again. Sometimes now, in Mrs Cameron's wrecked yard, we lay on the ground for hours, as still as a pair of fallen trees, as clouds of tiny black bugs hummed all around us.

"Without an enemy," said Tim, "it's not a real war."

I knew what he meant. The problem with the artillery barrages we endured all day long was that they weren't actually coming from anywhere; we had ground fire, plenty of it, but no shooter. And what was the fun of that? We had tried splitting up, chasing each other, but we were already too much of a team: it felt fake. There were other kids in the neighbourhood, but they were all much older or much younger; the younger kids were no fun to play with, and the older ones wouldn't have anything to do with us, even when we threw pebbles and tried to make them chase us.

"Let's go play under the hose," I said. I was forbidden to touch the hose and the outdoor faucets at my own house, and I couldn't understand Tim's lack of interest in water fights, especially since it was so hot.

"What about that little kid Brannon who lives in the white brick house?" suggested Tim.

"He's *way* too little. His mother doesn't let him go out of his own yard."

There was a long silence. Up front, we heard the door creak open — and all of a sudden, Tim's face lit up.

"Hey!" he said, in a hushed voice. He sat up; he listened. I sat up, too. A flash of excitement cracked through me at the tense bright expression on his face. And when we looked at each other, I realised that we were thinking the same thing.

Tim — trembling all over — put a finger to his lips. Then, silently, he motioned for me to follow. Quickly — in his doubled-up Marine crouch — he ran out of our brushy cover and out on to the lawn, and I ran out behind him, blood pounding with a fierce joy.

I've played and replayed this moment a lot in my mind over the years; and it all happened so quickly that even in memory it goes by too fast, I wince at it, knowing I can't stop it. We rounded the corner of the house — and then Tim, with his imaginary machine-gun, charged up the stairs to the front porch with me rushing in tight at his flank, bearing in fast, both of us spraying fire, *eck eck eck eck eck*. Of course, we knew very well that we were rushing either Tim's mother or Mrs Cameron, and we meant to scare the hell out of them. But what we didn't know was that Mrs Cameron wasn't on the porch, but halfway down the front stairs; and she was coming down them rather carefully, because she was wearing shoes with heels and carrying a plate of white-frosted cake in both hands.

We stopped short; but we didn't stop short enough. Her eyes rounded in horror and she reached for a railing that wasn't there, and then Mrs Cameron — with a faint gasping cry — fell backwards and slid down the stairs, all the way down to the concrete walk at the bottom, as the plate crashed on the ground.

Tim — as if it was all just part of the game — immediately dropped to his knees beside her: the perfect little field medic. "Don't worry," he said to her, bending low, in the tender but businesslike voice he sometimes used with me when I got hit. "Lie still. We'll get you to a doctor."

Frozen at the foot of the stairs, beside them, I found myself staring hard at the cake plate, which lay broken in big pieces on the ground. Blood pooled dark on the gritty concrete walk and — in a sick daze — I noticed that the pool was spreading out bigger and bigger every second.

Tim raised his head. "Mother?" he shouted. Then, to me, with admirable cool, he said: "Go get her."

I ran up the steps — bold with my mission, but also with a weird exhilarating sense of putting some sort of hard-earned emergency training into action — and collided with Tim's mother, who grabbed me by the shoulders and shoved me aside. As soon as she saw Mrs Cameron lying all bloody on the ground, she pressed her hands on both sides of her head and shrieked: "Oh my God!"

Mrs Cameron was crying, too, but in a way I didn't think grown-ups ever cried: wetly, noisily, with big gulps of air. Her forearm was cut, on the tender white underside; she'd cut it on the cake plate. That was where all the blood was coming from. The blood pumped out from it in a diagonal slash, streamed down her arm and dripped red off her fingertips, so much red it looked like Mrs Cameron was wearing a scarlet elbow glove.

"Oh my God!" screamed Tim's mother, looking frantically up into the tree branches, as if she expected to find help there.

"Go call, Evie!" said Tim, over his mother's shrieks. "911!"

I ducked behind Tim's mother — there was a telephone on a table in the front hall — but much to my shock, she caught me by the arm and whirled me around. "Don't you dare go in there!" Her face was bright red. I tried to pull my wrist away, but — almost before I could blink — she whacked me hard with her open hand across the face.

"*Little goyische girl!*" she screamed. "Run around over here like you own the damn place, eh? Lemme tell you something, girlie." She prodded me in the chest with her sharp forefinger. "Ya no good. This boy was never bad a day in his life."

Mrs Cameron, at the bottom of the steps was raising a frightened cry: "Gali? Gali?" She was struggling to get up. Tim was trying to hold her down.

"Ah, the hell with it." Tim's mother kicked the board game (*Operation*) which Tim and I had left spread out on the porch; and the pieces went flying — plastic funnybone, wishbone, heart.

She let go of me; and I backed away from her, down the stairs. She was crying, too.

"It's an ugly world," she said. "An ugly, stinking world."

Edging away from her — edging away from them all — at the bottom of the stairs I felt something slick touch my bare ankle, and I jumped. It was Mrs Cameron, her hand all bloody. She didn't say anything, but the look on her face was enough. I turned away from them and ran, out from Mrs Cameron's yard and the shadows of the oak trees into the hard shimmering heat of the sidewalk, no cover, just open space and open sky, streets so hostile in the midday sun that even my panic was drowned in all that emptiness and shrunk down to something flimsy and ridiculous.

Later, people said I'd been smart to run up to Main Street for help instead of toward my own house, which was blocks farther away. I never told anybody the truth: that my fear had spun me around and thrown me blindly off in the wrong direction.

But it wasn't just fear; it was a sick, bitter exaltation. And as I ran, the word she'd shouted at me pounded in my head: *goyische goyische goyische*, a strange word, screamed in a high, bad voice, a word that sounded like it had to mean something terrible, even if I didn't know what it was. Saigon would not fall for another year. And I was only eight; and Mrs Cameron would be home from the hospital in a couple of days with 17 stitches in her arm, but still — I knew it even then — I was as close at that moment to the real war as I was ever going to get ●

Tel 0207 206 1000 www.feburman.com

CYAN MAGENTA YELLOW BLACK

E. Burman Limited
Communications in Colour

The Guardian Weekend | June 25 2005 21

PDF/X overprint